All Will Be Forgiven?

Compassion, a Warning, and Our Shared Humanity

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> *"Truly I tell you, people can be forgiven all their sins and every slander they utter, but whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit will never be forgiven; they are guilty of an eternal sin."*
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> — Mark 3:28–29, New International Version (2011).[1]

1. Hearing the warning

In the span of a single breath, this remarkable saying opens forgiveness across the range of human sin and slander, then names a stark exception. Read as two detached statements, the words seem to pull us in opposite directions. Heard within an encounter, they may do something more: the breadth of the first makes the expression that follows all the more startling. Against the possibility of forgiveness for so much, Jesus places the gravity of what his hearers are saying. The contrast may be part of the force with which he is trying to reach them.[2]

The expression can be heard as a sharp warning, an effort to awaken those who have called the work of healing evil, or to disrupt the harmful judgment itself. It may also warn others witnessing the exchange. Jesus uses the language of judgment to challenge a judgment that turns the source of healing into an enemy. The severity draws attention to what that reversal means. A warning may carry compassion without sounding reassuring, and its care may extend beyond the people it directly addresses to those who could be affected by their words.

What the words declare, what speaking them seeks to accomplish, and what eventually happens to those addressed are related but distinct. A warning can seek to prevent a loss that the speaker regards as final; it can also confront a refusal that might yet change. Mark gives us the declaration and the encounter, not the hearers' final history. Hearing a compassionate purpose therefore leaves a real question before us: might this speech seek not only to change the accusers' minds, but also to interrupt the hold their accusation could acquire among those listening?

We bring our own histories to these words. Forgiveness may suggest pardon, release, or reconciliation; judgment may suggest moral discernment or condemnation. Jesus and those who heard him also spoke within a world of inherited meanings, loyalties, and disputes. A saying addressed to particular people carries that setting with it, even when it

[1] Biblica, *Holy Bible, New International Version* (2011), Mark 3:28–29. Scripture quotations marked NIV use this edition throughout. The close renderings below are supplied from the Greek rather than substituted for the NIV wording.

[2] Mark 3:22–30. The universal wording in verse 28 concerns human sins and blasphemies; verse 29 immediately qualifies it. It does not independently establish the final salvation of every person.

reaches far beyond the occasion. What happens when a specific expression in a lived moment becomes a judgment we pronounce about someone, or an entire community?

A teaching from another tradition can make familiar assumptions visible. Buddhist teachings bring a particular question to the encounter: what happens when we become attached not only to an opinion but to our sense of possessing the truth? The Order of Interbeing, founded by Thích Nhất Hạnh, extends its commitment to nonattachment to its own teachings, "even Buddhist ones." Such a comparison can deepen understanding while still honoring differences between these traditions.[3]

Jewish teaching also asks how firmly we should hold our own understanding. The Mishnah preserves rejected opinions of Hillel and Shammai to teach that a person should not insist on their own position (Eduyot 1:4). Much later, Rabbi Jonathan Sacks describes the ideal exemplified by Hillel's school: "They sought truth, not victory." The willingness to be corrected belongs here within a committed religious life. Buddhist nonattachment and rabbinic argument arise within different accounts of truth and practice, yet each can question the moment when fidelity to a teaching becomes the need to defend ourselves. Jewish interpretation thus enters both as attention to Jesus's own inheritance and as a continuing voice with questions of its own.[4]

The Gospels themselves confront the assumption that recognition belongs only within one's group. Jesus responds to a centurion's trust with astonishment: "I have not found anyone in Israel with such great faith" (Matthew 8:10, NIV). In Luke's parable of the Good Samaritan, the compassionate action comes from a Samaritan, a member of a related but contested Israelite tradition: he sees the wounded man and "took pity on him" (Luke 10:33, NIV). Religious differences do not disappear, but recognition and mercy need not come only from the place an audience expects.[5]

2. A teacher among people

The story before the saying

In Mark's opening chapter, the Spirit descends upon Jesus, who later proclaims that "The kingdom of God has come near" (1:15, NIV). Teaching, healing, and release from impure spirits give that proclamation a visible form. People gather around him; he also withdraws

[3] Order of Interbeing, *The Fourteen Mindfulness Trainings*, First–Third Trainings. The Jewish sources developed below include Exodus 34:6–7; Ezekiel 33:7–20; Sirach 28:1–7; Mishnah Yoma 8:9; and Maimonides, *Mishneh Torah*, Laws of Repentance 6:3. They belong to different periods, not a single reconstructed first-century position.

[4] Mishnah Eduyot 1:4, Hebrew text at Mechon Mamre. The explanation concerns preserving opinions that did not become the accepted ruling; it commends learning and correction within legal deliberation. Jonathan Sacks, "Argument for the Sake of Heaven," *Covenant & Conversation*, Korach, paragraph following his quotation of Eruvin 13b. Sacks discusses Avot 5:17 and Eruvin 13b, not Eduyot 1:4. These later witnesses do not establish what the scribes in Mark believed or prove a historical connection with Buddhist nonattachment.

[5] Matthew 8:5–13; Luke 10:25–37. The Samaritan in Luke's parable represents a real religious and social boundary within an intertwined Israelite inheritance, not a wholly unrelated religion. The comparison concerns recognition and compassionate action across an expected boundary; it does not establish that every religious claim is equally true.

to pray. From the beginning, the Gospel presents divine activity through a life moving among other lives, not through a list of propositions delivered outside any human setting.[6]

Questions develop around what this activity means. When Jesus forgives a paralyzed man, some scribes—learned interpreters of scripture and tradition; the NIV renders the Greek *grammateis* as "teachers of the law"—think, "He's blaspheming!" (2:7, NIV). His meals with people identified as sinners, and his disciples' conduct on the Sabbath, bring further challenges. Jesus responds through questions and images, including the physician who attends the sick and new wine that cannot be contained in old wineskins (2:17–22). Jesus and those questioning him share a Jewish scriptural world in which mercy, Torah, interpretation, and faithfulness already matter deeply. Their disputes concern how that inheritance is being lived.[7]

Sabbath observance belongs to that inheritance. In the Torah it is holy rest, extending to servants, resident foreigners, and animals; Deuteronomy also recalls liberation from slavery. Determining how the commandment applied in particular situations required interpretation. The dispute is therefore about how Torah is lived, not about administering a modern legal code. When chapter 3 opens with a man whose hand needs healing, some of those present watch to see whether Jesus will heal on the Sabbath so that they can accuse him. Jesus asks about doing good and saving life; the response is silence. Mark describes him as angry and "deeply distressed at their stubborn hearts" (3:5, NIV), then shows him restoring the man's hand.[8]

Later, so many people gather that Jesus and those with him cannot eat, and his family comes to take charge of him (3:20–21). Even those closest to him struggle to understand what is happening. The difficulty of receiving him reaches into family and community as well as religious debate. The saying about forgiveness emerges from this crowded, unsettled human world.

Mercy and warning within the Jewish inheritance

Mercy and moral consequence already stand together within the Jewish inheritance. In Exodus's proclamation of the divine name, God is "compassionate and gracious," "abounding in love and faithfulness," and "forgiving wickedness, rebellion and sin" (34:6–7, NIV). The same passage refuses to treat wrongdoing as inconsequential and speaks in difficult

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[6] Mark 1:9–15, 21–39. This is the Gospel's narrated sequence, not an independently recovered chronology of Jesus's ministry.

[7] Mark 2:1–28. In 2:6 the Greek noun is *grammateis*, conventionally rendered "scribes"; the NIV's "teachers of the law" is an interpretive English rendering. The NABRE describes scribes as trained in oral interpretation of written Torah. In 2:1–12 the accusation of blasphemy concerns Jesus's authority to forgive sins; the accusation in 3:22 concerns the source of his power over demons.

[8] Exodus 20:8–11; Deuteronomy 5:12–15; Mark 3:1–6. Compare the later permission to treat danger to life in Mishnah Yoma 8:6. That later formulation should not be projected backward as a complete description of the dispute over the non-emergency healing narrated by Mark.

language about guilt and consequences across generations. Compassion here is not indifference to harm; mercy and accountability are held together within the same sacred language.[9]

Ezekiel gives severe warning an explicitly life-seeking purpose. God declares, "I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked," then calls, "Turn! Turn from your evil ways!" (33:11, NIV). The following verses connect turning with restitution and changed conduct. The warning names a real danger, and the call to change is equally real. This does not decide the meaning of Mark's exception. It locates concern, judgment, and the possibility of turning within a Jewish scriptural inheritance that Jesus and his hearers share.[10]

From accusation to warning

The scribes who arrive from Jerusalem give Jesus's work a particularly damaging interpretation: "By the prince of demons he is driving out demons" (3:22, NIV). They associate his power with Beelzebul, the ruler of demons. They are not simply denying that something has happened. They name its source as evil. This is their accusation; what follows is Jesus's extraordinary response.[11]

Jesus responds by calling them over and asking, "How can Satan drive out Satan?" (3:23, NIV). A divided kingdom or household cannot stand; taking a strong man's possessions requires first overcoming him. These images challenge the accusation at its center. In Mark's telling, Jesus is breaking the hold of destructive power, not serving it. He addresses those making the accusation with reasons and images through which they might reconsider. The summons keeps the exchange an act of address, even amid sharp disagreement. Mark does not report how they receive this argument; the next recorded words sharpen the address.

Jesus speaks of the breadth of forgiveness and immediately follows it with the warning about blaspheming against the Holy Spirit. Mark explains the connection: they were saying, "He has an impure spirit" (3:30, NIV). The contrast between the Holy Spirit and an impure spirit is crucial because Mark gives this repeated attribution as the reason for the warning. What the narrative identifies with the Holy Spirit is being named as its opposite. The warning therefore answers not an abstract insult, but a reversal in the recognition of what is holy and healing.

Seen in this light, the opening promise of forgiveness is not merely a reassuring statement that the next sentence interrupts; it serves to heighten the warning. The movement from familiar images to words of such severity may be heard as an urgent attempt to awaken the hearers or to disrupt the harmful judgment taking shape around Jesus's work. Mark

[9] Exodus 34:6–7. The proclamation also describes consequences extending across generations. Its difficult account of responsibility must not be reduced to a modern therapeutic understanding of forgiveness.

[10] Ezekiel 33:7–20, especially 11, 14–16. Repentance here includes returning what was taken and acting justly; the call to turn is not detached from changed conduct.

[11] Mark 3:22–30. The following three paragraphs trace this one narrated address; no reply by the scribes is recorded between the parabolic argument and the warning.

records no reply between the argument and the warning. The rising intensity belongs to one continuing address, not a separately recorded failure of persuasion.

There is a further reversal across these chapters. Earlier, Jesus is accused of blasphemy because he forgives. Now the language of judgment turns back upon the judgment directed against his work. Jesus and the healing he offers are being denounced as instruments of evil. His response can be heard as a clear and powerful call, using words his hearers take seriously to confront what their accusation rejects and to challenge its authority. To oppose the Spirit of holiness is to turn against the very source of healing and forgiveness. So understood, the warning does more than classify a wrong: it confronts the rejection of what could bring release.[12]

The people making the accusation are likely the immediate addressees: Mark explicitly says that Jesus calls them over. Yet the exchange is framed by a crowd gathering around him (3:20) and a crowd seated around him afterward (3:32). His words may work within that wider circle as well. An accusation about the source of healing can shape more than the convictions of those who make it; it can influence what others fear, whom they trust, and whether they approach the one offering help. On this reading, interrupting the accusation also serves those whose possibilities it might close. The narrative makes that wider effect plausible without telling us that Jesus addresses every person present or how anyone responds.[13]

Disruption without retaliation

Walter Wink, an American biblical scholar, approaches Jesus's teaching on nonviolence as an alternative to both submission and violent retaliation. In his reading of Matthew's turning-the-cheek, cloak, and second-mile sayings, people resist a degrading relationship without accepting violence as their only means of resistance. He writes, "Loving confrontation can free both the oppressed from docility and the oppressor from sin." Yet he also warns that nonviolent action can be used for revenge and humiliation. Refusing physical violence does not, by itself, establish a loving purpose.[14]

Wink's discussion concerns Jesus's teaching on retaliation in Matthew 5:38–42, within the Sermon on the Mount, not this passage in Mark. It nevertheless opens a way of attending

[12] Compare Mark 2:7 with 3:22–30. The account of corrective purpose is an interpretation of the encounter, not an additional statement about Jesus's inward intention supplied by the narrator.

[13] Mark 3:20–35, especially 20, 22–23, and 31–32. The scribes are the immediate referent of "them" in verse 23. The surrounding crowd supplies a narrative basis for considering wider effects; the text neither lists everyone who heard the warning nor records the response of the crowd or scribes. The possibility that the speech interrupts an accusation's influence is an interpretive proposal, not an additional narrated event.

[14] Walter Wink, *Jesus and Nonviolence: A Third Way* (Fortress Press, 2003), ch. 2, pp. 25–28, quotation at 26. The comparison draws on his distinction between active nonviolent confrontation, retaliatory humiliation, and passivity, not on every detail of his reconstruction of Matthew 5. In "Beyond Just War and Pacifism: Jesus' Nonviolent Way," section "Beyond Just War and Pacifism," Wink explicitly allows nonviolent pressure that compels unwelcome choices. His account should not be equated with the absence of coercive pressure or with the Buddhist commitment not to impose beliefs. The application to Mark 3 is proposed here, not attributed to Wink.

to the encounter. Jesus refuses the interpretation imposed on his work and brings its consequences into question. He does not need to leave the accusation unanswered in order to refrain from retaliation. A sharp disruption may protect the possibility of healing for others as well as challenge those speaking against it. Care for a person and resistance to what the person is doing can belong to one action.

The severity makes this a demanding possibility, not an easy description. A threat of unforgivable sin can itself be used to silence dissent or secure obedience. Calling it nonviolent would explain nothing if the result were simply to sanctify intimidation. The question is whether the warning exposes a real harm and interrupts its power without making the people responsible disposable. We can hear a possible act of compassion here while continuing to ask what distinguishes truthful, protective confrontation from the religious use of fear.

A saying that unsettles its hearers

Seen together, the summons, the parables, and the warning suggest a form of teaching that aims not only to rebut an accusation but to interrupt a way of seeing. The words work within relationship: they warn, rebuke, invite, unsettle, and ask the hearer to recognize something the present judgment has obscured. A teacher may speak within familiar categories in order to expose what those categories have prevented someone from noticing. That possibility does not place Jesus outside his own culture. It asks how he works within it, addressing particular people whose response matters.

Zen practice offers a related way of encountering challenging speech. A saying can interrupt the understanding with which we approach it, rather than supply an answer that leaves us unchanged. Thích Nhất Hạnh describes this involvement in *Bat Nha: a Koan*, where the question becomes one's "own problem." Applied here, the question is no longer only which other person falls under the warning. It includes the judgments through which we ourselves hear it. A conclusion about the scribes in the story may leave those judgments untouched; entering the question can make them visible. Jesus's response begins with parables, and the severe saying belongs to the same address.[15]

This hearing also has a Christian precedent. John Chrysostom, a late-fourth-century preacher in Antioch, in Roman Syria, describes Jesus's purpose as "to do good to them that were sinning" (*Homily 41 on Matthew*, §1). Commenting on Matthew's parallel, he hears correction within confrontation. His interpretation retains severe judgment, but concern is not confined to reassuring speech.[16]

The human danger coming into view is not simply mistaken perception. It is clinging to a judgment so closely that we can no longer receive what might correct it. If liberation is

[15] Thích Nhất Hạnh, "Bat Nha: a Koan," opening account of koan practice. The comparison concerns how an inquiry includes the person undertaking it; it is not a claim that Mark belongs historically to the Zen genre or that Buddhist teaching influenced Jesus.

[16] John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew* 41.1, translated by George Prevost and revised by M. B. Riddle, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, first series, vol. 10 (1888). For Chrysostom's Antioch ministry, see Benedict XVI, "Saint John Chrysostom (1)," general audience, September 19, 2007.

named evil, liberation itself becomes something to resist. What could then be welcomed as healing? Mark does not explain the inner motives of those speaking, but his account makes this reversal of recognition visible. The danger is not merely that the scribes have chosen a damaging label. A judgment about the source of healing can shape whether we allow that healing to approach us at all. Yet the possibility that such resistance can change remains a further question; its present seriousness does not by itself answer it.

3. What the words keep open—and what they do not

Jesus is responding to the judgment that his liberating work is evil. Careful study of the language keeps that setting in view. The Gospel of Mark is commonly dated around 70 CE and understood to have been composed in Greek, several decades after Jesus's ministry. That is a date for composition, not for the surviving copies, and a Greek composition is not a transcript of an earlier spoken encounter. Mark preserves Aramaic words elsewhere, including "Talitha koum" in the raising of Jairus's daughter (5:41). First-century Palestine was multilingual: Aramaic was widely used, Hebrew remained in use, Greek was also present, and scholars differ over their relative roles. It is therefore plausible that Jesus knew and used more than one language, but the evidence does not identify the language of this exchange or of its earliest oral transmission. Nor has a lost Aramaic Gospel of Mark from which our Greek text was translated been established. The text below follows the *SBL Greek New Testament*, edited by Michael W. Holmes.[17]

The human work of translation was already recognized within Jewish tradition. In the prologue to Ben Sira, a Jewish wisdom book also called Sirach, the translator observes that Hebrew expression "does not have exactly the same effect when translated into another language" (prologue, lines 21–22, NRSVUE). This is not a reason to abandon the words. It is a reason to study them in relation to the life, language, and practice through which they are transmitted.[18]

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[17] Michael W. Holmes, ed., *The Greek New Testament: SBL Edition* (2010), Mark 3:28–30. Mark 5:41 preserves "Talitha koum." On the multilingual setting, see Steven E. Fassberg, "Which Semitic Language Did Jesus and Other Contemporary Jews Speak?" *Catholic Biblical Quarterly* 74.2 (2012), 263–280, and Stanley E. Porter, "Jesus and the Use of Greek: A Response to Maurice Casey," *Bulletin for Biblical Research* 10.1 (2000). Fassberg argues that Jesus's Aramaic is secure and that living Hebrew makes Hebrew competence highly likely; Porter argues for a greater role for Greek. These positions do not identify the language of Mark 3. For Palestinian Aramaic and later Syriac, see the Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon's "The Aramaic Language." A critical Greek edition reconstructs a written text from witnesses; it is not an autograph or transcript of Jesus's speech.

[18] Sirach, prologue, lines 21–22 (NRSVUE). The grandson's prologue distinguishes the Hebrew work from his Greek translation and applies the difficulty of translation to other scriptural books as well.

The words of the passage

Mark 3:28

Greek: Ἀμὴν λέγω ὑμῖν ὅτι πάντα ἀφεθήσεται τοῖς υἱοῖς τῶν ἀνθρώπων, τὰ ἁμαρτήματα καὶ αἱ βλασφημίαι ὅσα ἐὰν βλασφημήσωσιν·

Romanization: *Amēn legō hymin hoti panta aphethēsetai tois huiois tōn anthrōpōn, ta hamartēmata kai hai blasphēmiai hosa ean blasphēmēsōsin.*

Literal English: "Truly I say to you that all [πάντα, *panta*: all] will be forgiven [ἀφεθήσεται, *aphethēsetai*: will be forgiven] to the sons of human beings [τοῖς υἱοῖς τῶν ἀνθρώπων, *tois huiois tōn anthrōpōn*: to human beings / humanity]: the sins and the blasphemies, whatever they may blaspheme."

In natural English: "Truly I tell you, all human sins and whatever blasphemies people utter will be forgiven." The Greek verb is "will be forgiven"; the NIV opening renders the statement "can be forgiven." The entire movement matters, rather than any isolated phrase.[19]

Mark 3:29

Greek: ὃς δ' ἂν βλασφημήσῃ εἰς τὸ πνεῦμα τὸ ἅγιον, οὐκ ἔχει ἄφεσιν εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα, ἀλλὰ ἔνοχός ἐστιν αἰωνίου ἁμαρτήματος.

Romanization: *Hos d' an blasphēmēsē eis to pneuma to hagion, ouk echei aphesin eis ton aiōna, alla enochos estin aiōniou hamartēmatos.*

Literal English: "But whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit does not have forgiveness [ἄφεσιν, *aphesin*: forgiveness / remission] into the age [εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα, *eis ton aiōna*: into / unto the age], but is answerable for an eternal sin [αἰωνίου ἁμαρτήματος, *aiōniou hamartēmatos*: of an eternal sin]."

In natural English: "But whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit never has forgiveness, but is guilty of an eternal sin." "Has no forgiveness forever" is another close rendering. The idiom containing "age" gives an emphatic denial; it does not specify a period after which forgiveness resumes. "Answerable" distinguishes being held accountable for wrongdoing from the inward feeling of guilt. It does not reduce the passage to a financial debt or remove its seriousness.[20]

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[19] SBLGNT, Mark 3:28. The future passive *aphethēsetai* is "will be forgiven"; the NIV's "can be forgiven" is a translation decision, not an alternative Greek tense. The inclusive expression "sons of human beings" concerns humanity, not males alone.

[20] Robert G. Bratcher and Eugene A. Nida, *A Handbook on the Gospel of Mark* (1961), commentary on 3:29–30, excerpt hosted by the American Bible Society's Translation Insights and Perspectives (TIPs); William D. Mounce, online Greek dictionary, s.v. "enochos." The handbook explains the age-idiom as an emphatic temporal denial. Compare Mark 11:14 and the distinct "until the end of the age" wording in Matthew 28:20.

Mark 3:30

Greek: ὅτι ἔλεγον· Πνεῦμα ἀκάθαρτον ἔχει.

Romanization: *Hoti elegon: pneuma akatharton echei.*

Literal English: "Because they were saying, 'An unclean spirit he has.'"

In natural English: "Because they were saying, 'He has an unclean spirit.'" The NIV uses "impure" for *akatharton*. Mark's explanation joins the warning to the accusation already being made.[21]

The language is forceful. The breadth of forgiveness heightens the exception without becoming empty rhetoric, and the Greek does not remove the severity. The warning concerns what these people are already saying about Jesus's work. What its denial of forgiveness means for them remains a question inside the translated words.

The final phrase also resists an easy resolution. The critical SBLGNT reads "eternal sin"; the Textus Receptus reads "eternal judgment." The difference is in the noun, not a softer temporal statement. "Eternal sin" does not itself specify a punishment, but it does speak of being answerable for wrongdoing. Neither a complete theory of punishment nor a purely inward account of blocked healing is contained in those words alone. Their meaning is sought within the story, the wider scriptural witness, and the continuing experience of repentance, mercy, and consequence.[22]

The Syriac Peshitta, a later Gospel version in a literary form of Aramaic, lets us hear the teaching in Syriac without recovering Jesus's original utterance. It contrasts *rūḥā d-qudšā*, "Spirit of holiness," with *rūḥā ṭanpṭā*, "an impure spirit." The repeated word for spirit makes the reversal audible: what is named holy is being called impure. The Peshitta likewise ends with "judgment that is forever" (study rendering), rather than the critical Greek's "eternal sin"; this may reflect its Greek exemplar, a translation choice, later revision, or some combination that this study does not resolve. Holiness, however, is not simply another word for purity.[23]

Its denial of forgiveness is equally forceful: *layt leh šubqānā l-ʿālam*, "there is no forgiveness for him forever" (study rendering). *L-ʿālam* is a conventional Syriac expression for "forever"; the underlying word-family can also refer to age, world, and time, but nothing in this phrase supplies an endpoint. The noun *šubqānā* also names remission, as in the

[21] SBLGNT, Mark 3:30; Bratcher and Nida, commentary on 3:29–30. The imperfect *elegon* supplies the explanation "they were saying." Neither it nor the aorist subjunctive "blasphemes" in verse 29 supplies a clause promising forgiveness once the saying stops.

[22] Bratcher and Nida, commentary on Mark 3:29–30, discusses the critical reading *hamartēmatos* ("sin") and the Textus Receptus reading *kriseōs* ("judgment"). The variation does not by itself establish a motive for a scribal change or the history of every witness. For the ancient judicial range of *enochos*, compare Mark 14:64 and Matthew 5:21.

[23] Peshitta, Mark 3:29–30, British and Foreign Bible Society text displayed by Dukhrana Biblical Research, with George A. Kiraz's SEDRA analysis. The Peshitta's final noun concerns judgment; the SBLGNT's concerns sin. This essay does not determine whether the Syriac wording reflects a Greek exemplar, translation choice, later revision, or a combination. The Syriac phrases and romanizations are study aids, not a reconstruction of Galilean speech.

Syriac version of the release of debts in Deuteronomy 15:1. The vocabulary allows pardon to be heard alongside release from an obligation, an association also present in the Lord's Prayer. Yet the sentence here denies that release. The Aramaic witness deepens our attention to what forgiveness can mean without giving us a gentler substitute for the warning.[24]

The Greek word *aiōn*—from which English *eon* comes through Latin—can name an age or world-order as well as an extent of time. In Mark's negative idiom the natural force remains "never" or "forever"; the lexical history does not turn the warning into a limited term. It does remind us that ancient religious language about time need not be reduced to our modern image of an indefinitely extended sequence of identical moments. Matthew's contrast between this age and the coming one makes the age-horizon explicit. What the idiom asserts and how a life participates in past, present, and future are related questions, not identical ones.[25]

Forgiveness, turning, and responsibility

Our English words bring other associations into the question of what forgiveness means. In the Lord's Prayer, Matthew has "forgive us our debts" (6:12, NIV), while Luke begins "Forgive us our sins" and then uses language of indebtedness, as the NIV's Greek-text footnote explains (11:4). The noun for forgiveness in Mark 3:29, *aphesis*, likewise belongs to the language of release and remission. Pardon, freedom from a burden, and the restoration of a relationship can illuminate one another without being the same thing. Divine forgiveness concerns a person's relation to God; reconciliation between people also requires attention to what has happened between them, and restored trust cannot simply be pronounced into being.[26]

Jewish reflection already joins seeking mercy to how we treat another person. Ben Sira says, "Forgive your neighbor the wrong he has done" (Sirach 28:2, NRSVUE), then connects that act with asking forgiveness in prayer. Later rabbinic teaching distinguishes wrongs against God from wrongs against another person: the latter are not atoned for by the Day of Atonement alone, "until one has appeased one's fellow" (Mishnah Yoma 8:9; study rendering from Hebrew). A religious act does not simply discharge the responsibility to the person harmed. The same rabbinic passage ends with Rabbi Akiva's joyful address to Israel: "Who purifies you? Your Father in heaven" (study rendering). Divine care and the

[24] Peshitta Mark 3:29, BFBS text displayed by Dukhrana, with Kiraz's SEDRA analysis; Comprehensive Aramaic Lexicon, entry *šwbqn*, senses 2–3, citing Peshitta Deuteronomy 15:1 for remission. These are attested uses of the Syriac noun, not evidence that every occurrence carries all its senses. The Peshitta Old Testament and New Testament have different translation histories; see "Peshitta," *Gorgias Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Syriac Heritage*. The romanization is a study aid, not reconstructed Galilean pronunciation; no softer temporal meaning or previously lost words of Jesus are claimed.

[25] Mounce, s.vv. "aion" and "aionios"; Merriam-Webster, s.v. "eon," word history. Matthew 12:32 explicitly names both this age and the coming one. Etymology and a dictionary's range of senses cannot determine the scope of a particular sentence.

[26] Matthew 6:12; Luke 11:4 and its NIV Greek-text note. For *aphesis*, see Mounce, s.v. "aphesis"; compare release from captivity in Luke 4:18 with forgiveness of sins in Luke 24:47. These are contextual uses of a shared noun, not interchangeable definitions.

obligation to the injured person sound together. The hope of purification does not make the work of repair unnecessary, and the demand for repair does not exhaust what the tradition says about mercy.[27]

This continuing tradition also contains difficult accounts of hardening. The medieval Jewish philosopher and legal scholar Moses Maimonides allows that grave, deliberate wrongdoing can result in a judgment by which "repentance is withheld from him" (*Laws of Repentance* 6:3; study rendering). These later teachings are not a record of what Jesus's contemporaries all believed. They show a living inquiry into mercy, responsibility, and the possibility of turning—not a uniformly reassuring alternative to Christian judgment.[28]

Interpretations over time

The possibility of repentance brings us back to the people in Mark. They have already attributed Jesus's work to an impure spirit, and he calls them over to speak about what they are saying. If they come to recognize what they have rejected, what would that recognition mean for the warning they have received? Would repentance reveal that the warning had accomplished its purpose, or would it contradict a final judgment already pronounced? Mark does not tell us how they respond. Christian interpreters have returned to this question through different understandings of repentance, mercy, and judgment.

John Chrysostom asks whether even repentance would be ineffective, then writes, "For even this was forgiven upon repentance" (*Homily 41*, §5). He says some who made the accusation subsequently believed. Yet he also describes grave punishment, and his homily contains anti-Jewish polemic that interprets collective suffering punitively. His hopeful sentence belongs to that troubling larger account. He is a human interpreter whose insights and harmful judgments both require attention.[29]

Augustine of Hippo, bishop and theologian in late-fourth- and early-fifth-century North Africa, identifies the decisive condition with final impenitence: refusal of repentance maintained until death. For the living, however, he insists, "For we are not to despair of any" (*Sermon 71*, §21). The thirteenth-century theologian Thomas Aquinas takes up this reading as a warning against reaching that condition. He also distinguishes rejection of

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[27] Sirach 28:1–7, especially 28:2 (NRSVUE); Mishnah Yoma 8:9, Hebrew text at Mechon Mamre, where the passage is displayed as 8:7 [9]. The English clause from Yoma is a study rendering of *ʿad she-yeraṣṣeh et ḥavero*. Its setting concerns atonement and obligation to the person wronged, not a requirement to restore an unsafe relationship. The unit ends with Rabbi Akiva addressing Israel and describing God's purification through Ezekiel 36:25 and Jeremiah 17:13. "Who purifies you? Your Father in heaven" is a study rendering of the concluding question and answer, not a quotation attributed to a modern English edition.

[28] Maimonides, *Mishneh Torah*, Laws of Repentance 6:3; compare 2:9 on restitution and seeking pardon for interpersonal wrongs. The short English rendering is supplied from the Hebrew displayed by Mechon Mamre. At 6:3, the argument includes Pharaoh and Isaiah 6:10; this is a theology of judicial hardening, not merely a psychological observation.

[29] John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew* 41.5, translated by Prevost, revised by Riddle. He writes: "For even this was forgiven upon repentance. Many at least of those who said these words believed afterward, and all was forgiven them." His report that some accusers later believed is part of his interpretation; Mark itself does not narrate their later response. The same section speaks of punishment in this life and the next and applies it polemically to Jewish collective suffering.

the means of pardon from a limit on an "all-powerful and merciful God" (*Summa theologiae*, II–II, q.14, aa.1, 3). Neither removes final judgment, but both leave reason to hesitate before declaring a living person unreachable.[30]

John Calvin, sixteenth-century Reformation theologian based in Geneva, draws the boundary around knowing rejection of recognized truth. Those who enter this condition, he says, "never have any desire towards repentance." His reading is not that God refuses a repentant person; it is that repentance will not arise.[31]

The Catholic Catechism also takes refusal seriously, affirming "There are no limits to the mercy of God" (§1864) before describing rejection of repentance and possible final loss. The nineteenth-century Scottish writer and preacher George MacDonald presses further, refusing to regard the condition as "a fixed, a final condition" (*It Shall Not Be Forgiven*). Whether resistance can itself ultimately change is where these readings diverge.[32]

Each account brings something consequential to the saying: a distinction between ignorance and knowing rejection, a boundary at death, or trust in a further possibility of transformation. These are efforts to understand the warning within a larger vision of God and human life. Their differences cannot be settled by a dictionary alone, but neither are they detached from the words. Interpretation involves both attention to the particular saying and judgment about the life and teaching to which it belongs.

The severity remains

Matthew's parallel states that forgiveness will not come "either in this age or in the age to come" (12:32, NIV). This is a substantial reason for taking the warning's finality seriously. A compassionate purpose can coexist with a conviction that the danger is irreversible.

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[30] Augustine, *Sermon 71* (21 in the NPNF/New Advent sequence), §§20–21, translated by R. G. MacMullen; Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* II–II, q.14, aa.1, 3, translated by the Fathers of the English Dominican Province. Augustine writes: "But this impenitence or impenitent heart may not be pronounced upon, as long as a man lives in the flesh." Aquinas likewise says, in a.3, reply to objection 1: "We should despair of no man in this life, considering God's omnipotence and mercy." Augustine counsels hope while a person remains alive; Aquinas distinguishes final impenitence from a sin that excludes the ordinary means of remission.

[31] John Calvin, *Commentary on a Harmony of the Evangelists, Matthew, Mark, and Luke*, translated by William Pringle, commentary on Matthew 12:31–32 and the Synoptic parallels. Knowing, malicious repudiation and divinely imposed hardening that prevents a later desire to repent are premises of Calvin's interpretation; Mark does not explicitly report the accusers' private recognition of the truth.

[32] *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, §1864; George MacDonald, "It Shall Not Be Forgiven," in *Unspoken Sermons*. MacDonald's separate discussion of an age or era occurs in "Light," not in the sermon quoted here. MacDonald makes the relation between severity and mercy explicit: "But the very word that told them of the unpardonable state in which they were, was just the one form the voice of mercy could take in calling on them to repent. They must hear and be afraid." His account is a theological interpretation, not evidence that Mark's idiom contains an endpoint; he also assumes an inward recognition of goodness that Mark does not expressly narrate.

Someone can coherently hear both care for the people addressed and a final limit to forgiveness. That reading deserves an answer, not a diagnosis of closed-mindedness. Conversely, a reading that hopes for transformation must explain why the warning can be heard that way without silently adding "only while the refusal continues" to its wording.[33]

Mark 4 raises a further question about what parables do. Jesus distinguishes those who have received the kingdom's secret from those outside, then connects parabolic speech to their failure to understand with the words "so that." Drawing on Isaiah, the saying ends, "otherwise they might turn and be forgiven!" (4:11–12, NIV). The difficulty concerns not only a failure to listen, but the role of the teaching itself in what is disclosed or concealed. Yet the same chapter says that what is hidden is meant to be made known (4:21–22), and urges, "Consider carefully what you hear" (4:24, NIV). Whatever precise force we give the "otherwise," Mark places the promise of disclosure beside the disturbing possibility of seeing without perceiving and hearing without understanding. Parabolic teaching can both reveal and expose an inability to hear. The passage does not independently establish that exclusion is eternal, nor does it promise that every parable will open understanding.[34]

Reason can carry us into this tension. It can test what follows from the words, expose hidden premises, and keep us from treating preference as interpretation. But it need not force every religious utterance to operate on one level of description or yield an abstract system free of paradox. The task is harder: to use language study, reason, history, experience, and contemplative insight together until the tension discloses a meaningful, practicable understanding. A seeming contradiction is not permission to make the text mean anything; it is sometimes the place where our first categories prove too narrow.

What changes when we hear the saying as an address is not necessarily its truth, but our position in relation to it. Before it becomes an answer about someone else's destiny, it can become a question about our own way of seeing. The language remains severe enough to disturb us. We need not settle everything about eternity before allowing that disturbance to reveal something in our lives.

4. When certainty closes the heart

Clinging to a view

Clinging to a view is not the same as reasoning carefully or holding a conviction. Reason can expose contradictions, test an inference, and bring us to the point where the categories we began with no longer seem adequate. The danger begins when keeping a judgment becomes more important than discovering what is true. The scribes' description of Jesus's work gives that danger a concrete form: liberation is named evil and becomes something

[33] Matthew 12:31–32. The phrase excludes both the present age and the coming age; a restoration beyond both would require a further theological argument, not merely a different dictionary gloss for "age."

[34] Mark 4:10–12, 21–25, drawing on Isaiah 6:9–10. The NIV renders the conjunction in 4:12 as "so that." The relation among prophetic judgment, irony, concealment, and eventual disclosure remains interpretively contested; the essay does not settle it by altering the translation. The narrower claim is that Mark places disclosure beside nonrecognition, so that parabolic teaching can reveal while also exposing an inability to hear.

to resist rather than receive. Dogmatism gives this attachment a doctrinal form. We judge everything by the teaching as we have understood it, but no longer allow what happens, or what another person tells us, to question that understanding.

The Order of Interbeing, founded by Thích Nhất Hạnh, places this danger within the First Mindfulness Training. Practitioners commit to "transform dogmatism and violence in ourselves and the world." Buddhist doctrines are included within its warning against attachment. The practice concerns how we hold our own tradition, not only the errors we identify outside it. The Second Training develops the commitment through listening and continued learning. Nonattachment is not an absence of moral direction; it is part of how understanding and compassion are cultivated.[35]

Some Buddhist scripture works directly with the limits of fixed designation. In Thích Nhất Hạnh's translation of the *Diamond Sutra*, the bodhisattva is called to lead all beings to liberation while being instructed not to grasp the notion that a separately existing being has been liberated. The tension is not permission to disregard the words; it cuts into fixed notions of self, person, and living being. A designation can function conventionally while failing to exhaust a deeper reality.[36]

Mark 3 is not constructed as this kind of deliberate Buddhist paradox, and the comparison should not be forced. Its tension arises from a concrete accusation and warning. But the *Diamond Sutra* helps name the discipline needed here: reasoning can bring us to paradox, distinguish the levels at which our words are working, and show where a fixed conceptual frame fails. Insight is not an escape from reasoning; it is what can become possible when reasoning has done enough work to reveal the limits of the notions with which we began.

The Babylonian Talmud gives this openness a concrete discipline. In its account of the disputes between the schools of Hillel and Shammai, the teaching of Hillel's school is preferred because its members study both positions and "put the words of the House of Shammai before their own" (Eruvin 13b; study rendering). They make room for the other account within their own teaching. A practical ruling still follows; listening does not dissolve the need to decide. This later rabbinic teaching offers a demanding question for any interpreter: can we allow another person's understanding to become clear before explaining why ours should prevail?[37]

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[35] Order of Interbeing, *The Fourteen Mindfulness Trainings*, First, "Openness," and Second, "Non-Attachment to Views." These are commitments of a particular Buddhist tradition; they neither dismiss doctrine nor guarantee the openness of every practitioner.

[36] *The Diamond That Cuts Through Illusion* (*Vajracchedikā Prajñāpāramitā Sūtra*), translated by Thích Nhất Hạnh, official Plum Village text. The discourse instructs bodhisattvas to lead innumerable beings to liberation while not grasping the notion that a separately existing being has been liberated. The comparison concerns the way a fixed designation can obscure a deeper relation; it is not evidence that Mark 3 is historically a Buddhist koan, nor permission to ignore grammar, history, or context.

[37] Babylonian Talmud, Eruvin 13b, passage beginning with Rabbi Abba's report in the name of Samuel, Hebrew/Aramaic text at Mechon Mamre. The English clause is a project study rendering. The passage affirms the standing of both schools' words while directing practice according to Hillel's school; it commends teaching the other position and placing it first, not an absence of judgment. The later compilation is not a transcript of the first-century exchange in Mark.

Mark directs this concern about failed recognition toward the disciples too. Jesus asks them, “Are your hearts hardened?” and “[D]on’t you remember?” (8:17–18, NIV), then continues to teach them. Later they try to stop someone driving out demons in Jesus’s name because “he was not one of us”; Jesus answers, “Do not stop him” (9:38–39, NIV). Attachment to belonging threatens to obstruct the work they claim to serve. Difficulty in recognizing what is good belongs within the circle of disciples as well as beyond it.[38]

These episodes keep the people in the earlier encounter human. The scribes, the Pharisees, Jesus’s family, and his disciples are not interchangeable, but neither need any become the embodiment of a permanent defect. Each meets what they do not understand through commitments and histories of their own. The seriousness of a harmful accusation does not give a complete account of the person who makes it.

Paul and changed seeing

Paul’s life gives the possibility of change particular weight. He recalls, “I persecuted the church of God and tried to destroy it,” before describing God’s revelation of the Son (Galatians 1:13–16, NIV). Acts tells the change through blindness, restored sight, and Ananias’s words: “you may see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit” (9:17, NIV). The person who had worked to destroy the community comes to recognize what he had opposed.[39]

First Timothy qualifies its account of mercy: “I acted in ignorance and unbelief” (1:13, NIV). This canonical portrayal has disputed authorship and should not simply be merged with Paul’s own account in Galatians or with Acts’ narrative. The distinction between ignorance and knowing rejection matters, and none of these passages establishes that Paul made the particular accusation in Mark. His life does not cancel the warning. It does prevent destructive religious opposition from becoming, by itself, proof that a person cannot change. Paul’s own severe words against a different gospel also keep him from becoming a simple emblem of openness: transformation does not remove every hard boundary from a person’s convictions.[40]

Nor does receptivity have to begin as an achievement a person produces alone. An encounter can interrupt the understanding through which everything else has been interpreted. Paul attributes his change of direction to God’s revelation of the Son; Acts connects restored sight with the gift of the Spirit. “If we refuse to see, we do not see” remains a searching formulation, but refusal need not be the last thing that happens to us. What becomes possible when we encounter what our settled understanding could not receive?

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[38] Mark 8:14–21; 9:38–41; compare 6:52. The man in 9:38 acts in Jesus’s name while standing outside the disciples’ group. The passage challenges their attempted prohibition without making every claimed healing self-authenticating.

[39] Galatians 1:13–16; Acts 9:1–19. Paul’s letter and Acts’ narrative are distinct literary witnesses. Galatians 1:8–9 supplies the counterweight concerning Paul’s own severe boundary against a different gospel.

[40] 1 Timothy 1:12–16; on the disputed authorship of the Pastoral Epistles, see the USCCB introduction to 1 Timothy. The qualification concerning ignorance cannot establish either ignorance or knowing rejection on the part of Mark’s scribes.

That question concerns transformation, not automatic absolution. Changed perception does not erase harm, establish divine forgiveness, or oblige another person to restore trust. A changing person can bear a lasting consequence. Responsibility and the possibility of becoming different remain together.

The warning turns toward its interpreters

Clinging to a view can also shape Christian interpretation. We can defend an account of goodness while refusing to hear those harmed by its application. Even forgiveness can be used this way when it requires an injured person to stop speaking before responsibility has been acknowledged. A boundary against further harm is not closed-heartedness, and reluctance to trust a teacher's claimed healing is not blasphemy.

The Gospel's own test of profession is demanding. Matthew warns about those who say "Lord, Lord" (7:21, NIV), including people who claim powerful deeds in Jesus's name. The judgment scene in chapter 25 brings recognition into acts of care for those who are hungry, sick, or imprisoned: "whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me" (25:40, NIV). The identity of those described as the least remains debated, and the ending is severe. Yet religious profession is plainly not a substitute for responding to a life before us.[41]

Christian anti-Judaism makes the stakes historical as well as personal. In its account of the German churches under Nazism, the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum records that "traditional interpretations of religious scriptures seemed to support these prejudices." Inherited Christian teaching, Nazi racial ideology, state power, and different forms of complicity and resistance belong to this history. Christian teaching was not its single cause, but its part cannot be omitted. Nor can the suffering of Jewish people be reduced to a lesson about someone else's spiritual growth.[42]

The responsibility includes questioning interpretations that enabled people and institutions to disregard Jewish lives. It also includes correction: the Second Vatican Council's declaration *Nostra aetate* §4 states that Jews "should not be presented as rejected or accursed by God." The declaration does not undo earlier injury, but shows that authoritative teaching can restrain harm as well as be used to sustain it. The problem is not simply that there is a doctrine. It is whether that doctrine and its application remain answerable to the truth and human dignity they claim to serve.[43]

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[41] Matthew 7:15–27; 25:31–46. The USCCB note to Matthew 25:31–46 records disagreement about the identity of "the least" and favors disciples acting as missionaries. The scene concludes with eternal punishment and eternal life (25:46); an ethical application must retain that severity.

[42] United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "The German Churches and the Nazi State," sections "Background," "Protestant Churches in Nazi Germany," and "Summary." This is a historical synthesis, not a primary document from the Nazi period. It describes differences among Christian responses as well as the contribution of inherited anti-Jewish teaching.

[43] Second Vatican Council, *Nostra aetate*, October 28, 1965, §4. The declaration rejects collective Jewish responsibility for Jesus's death and condemns antisemitism; its doctrinal commitments should not be confused with an abandonment of Christian particularity.

The antidote to dogmatism is therefore not indifference. It includes study, prayer, listening, concrete care, and willingness to change what we do when harm becomes visible. It also leaves room for honest disagreement. Another person's refusal to accept our interpretation does not establish that their heart is closed. The same test returns upon a compassionate reading of Mark: if we dismiss every difficult verse or contrary interpretation as a failure of compassion, we have protected our own view from the encounter we ask of others.

5. Humanity without distance from the divine

The call to look again does not stop with those whom Jesus addresses. It also concerns how we see Jesus himself. Reverence can bring us close to a life, but it can also place that life at such a distance that we no longer hear a person speaking to other people. Then a warning becomes a timeless classification before we have attended to the act of address. Recovering the human encounter does not weaken the words; it restores the relation in which their force is first felt.

A human teacher, a human transmission

The teaching reaches us through lives as well as words. Matthew retains the exchange about Jesus's power; Luke places the warning beside the promise that "the Holy Spirit will teach you at that time what you should say" (12:12, NIV). The different settings guide different acts of understanding. *Dei verbum*, the Second Vatican Council's constitution on divine revelation, recognizes the evangelists as "selecting some things from the many which had been handed on" (§19), while affirming the truth of the Gospels. Interpretation already participates in how the tradition is given, not simply in what later readers add.[44]

Jesus's humanity belongs within this stream. Luke says that he "grew in wisdom" (2:52, NIV); John shows him "tired as he was from the journey" (4:6, NIV). Mark gives us prayer, anger, grief, questions, and encounters under pressure. These are not incidental concessions to a human appearance. They are part of the life through which his teaching is encountered. A human teacher speaks to particular hearers, with words that may console in one moment and confront in another.[45]

To attend to this humanity is not to take something from his divinity. The Catholic Catechism itself holds together "true God and true man" (§464), and, quoting the Second Vatican Council, affirms his human thought and says that "with a human heart he loved" (§470). That tradition makes claims beyond describing a divinely inspired teacher, but it

[44] Matthew 12:22–32; Luke 12:8–12; Second Vatican Council, *Dei verbum*, November 18, 1965, §19. The constitution recognizes selection, synthesis, and explanation while affirming that the evangelists told the truth about Jesus; it is not an endorsement of every possible account of fallibility.

[45] Luke 2:52; John 4:6; Mark 1:35; 3:5. These texts describe human life and circumstance; they do not establish any particular claim that Jesus committed a moral or doctrinal error.

also gives genuine humanity a central place. Human thought, love, and relationship are not what must be removed before the divine can be encountered.[46]

The only child and the whole world

The language of divine sonship can seem to place Jesus at an unreachable distance. John calls him God's "one and only Son" (3:16, NIV), yet also speaks of those who receive him becoming "children of God" (1:12, NIV). These statements are not identical, but neither is the second insignificant. The Gospel's particular claim about Jesus accompanies an invitation into relationship with God.[47]

The word *monogenēs*, traditionally translated "only begotten," identifies the only or unique one in a relationship; in John 3:16 it refers to Jesus. Alongside that particular claim, the image of an only child can open another question about love. Could each person be loved *as if an only child*, with a care that does not treat anyone as expendable? This is a contemplative extension of the image, not an account of where John's expression historically came from. It asks about the quality of a love that the same verse extends toward the world. An only child is not loved as one interchangeable instance of a category. The comparison invites care that sees a particular life, even when that care must confront what the person is doing.

The Buddhist *Discourse on Love* makes a related movement. In Thích Nhất Hạnh's translation, the example is "[j]ust as a mother loves and protects her only child at the risk of her own life." Such wholehearted loving-kindness is to be extended to all beings. Matthew's call to "love your enemies" (5:44, NIV), grounded in the Father's care for the evil and the good, offers a Christian point of encounter. Neither passage makes harmful conduct harmless. Both unsettle the division of care according to who belongs, who agrees, or who has become difficult to love.[48]

The people addressed in Mark remain within that field of care. Their accusation is serious, and Jesus can confront it without their humanity disappearing. His concern need not depend on their agreement. The question is not whether their words matter, but whether those words become all that can be seen of them.

A person is more than a description

A statement about what someone has done can become the final account of who they are. This is not a choice between logic and insight. Careful reasoning can expose the hidden step from "this person did harm" to "this is all this person can ever be"; insight

[46] *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, §§464, 467, 470–474. Section 470 quotes the Second Vatican Council's *Gaudium et spes*, §22. The adjacent treatment of human knowledge is qualified by the Catechism's affirmation of divine knowledge; the humanity claim should not be isolated from those commitments.

[47] John 3:16; 1:12–14; Mounce, s.v. "monogenes." The unique Son and those becoming children of God are not interchangeable referents. The only-child image developed here is a contemplative comparison, not a replacement translation of *monogenēs*.

[48] *Discourse on Love* (*Mettā Sutta*, Sutta Nipāta 1.8), translated by Thích Nhất Hạnh, official Plum Village text; Matthew 5:43–48. The Buddhist passage instructs practitioners to cultivate boundless loving-kindness; it does not make a claim about a creator God.

asks whether the description we are using is adequate to the living person before us. A truthful account of harmful actions remains necessary without becoming an exhaustive account of a life.[49]

Thích Nhất Hạnh approaches historical and ultimate dimensions through the image of wave and water. The wave's arising and passing are not denied, but neither do they exhaust what the wave is. He cautions that "interbeing does not mean that everything is one or that everything is different." This invites attention to two forms of closure: identifying someone completely with a past act, or imagining that transformation produces an unrelated person with no responsibility for it. In relation to Mark, this does not establish that an eternal consequence is impossible. It helps us distinguish a person's act, the person who remains answerable for it, and the possibility of a different response. None should be made to disappear into the others.[50]

Time as lived, remembered, and anticipated

The question of a different response brings time back into view. Mark's "never" cannot be softened by a more attractive account of eternity. But a warning is spoken in the present to people whose past judgments are still shaping what they can receive. How a person carries the past is therefore not only a question of elapsed time. Jewish Passover practice makes a past deliverance part of present identity and obligation. Mishnah Pesachim requires each person, in every generation, to regard themselves "as though they had come out of Egypt" (10:5; study rendering from Hebrew). This later rabbinic formulation develops the first-person language of Exodus 13:8. The event is not simply over and absent; remembrance enters how life is lived now.[51]

Augustine offers a different but related attention to time in his *Confessions*: "a present of things past, a present of things present, and a present of things future" (XI.20.26). He locates these in memory, present awareness, and expectation. This account of lived time coexists with his understanding of final impenitence: the same thinker still places a decisive boundary at death. His attention to time helps us ask how the past is present without settling the question of final forgiveness.[52]

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[49] The distinction here concerns the adequacy of a description, not a proposed alternative to logical consistency. From a present refusal it does not follow, without another premise, that refusal must always continue. Equally, the possibility of change does not establish forgiveness or eliminate an enduring consequence. Mark's temporal qualification still needs to be interpreted.

[50] Thích Nhất Hạnh, interviewed by Melvin McLeod, "This Is the Buddha's Love," *Shambhala Sun*, March 2006; republished by Plum Village. See the discussion of wave and water and the question about interpreting interbeing as universal oneness. The ethical application to continuing responsibility is a constructive comparison, not a quotation from the interview.

[51] Mishnah Pesachim 10:5, Hebrew text at Mechon Mamre; compare Exodus 13:8. The English phrase is a study rendering. The obligation is personal in every generation; the later rabbinic text should not be treated as a transcript of Jesus's understanding of time.

[52] Augustine, *Confessions* XI.20.26, translated by J. G. Pilkington; compare XI.28.37–38 on reciting a psalm. For final impenitence, see *Sermon 71*, §§20–21. His account of temporal experience does not itself imply forgiveness after death.

John's Gospel also speaks of someone who already "has eternal life," while retaining a future resurrection and judgment (5:24–29, NIV). These different accounts should not be gathered into a single philosophy. Together they caution against assuming that the duration of life exhausts what religious language says about participating in it. Nor does attending to lived time require abandoning chronology.[53]

Sister Annabel Laity (True Virtue) connects this attention to time with regret and present responsibility: "The three times inter-are." Past action continues in its consequences; how we respond now helps form what comes next. Her discussion of regret turns toward acting differently in the present, not making the past unhappen. Transformation can mean entering responsibility more fully. It does not require another person to forgive, reconcile, or restore access, and it does not decide how long a consequence may endure.[54]

The relation among the times therefore matters alongside their duration. A past act is not changed into something that never happened, yet its continuation can involve remorse, repair, renewed harm, or a different way of living. This does not make "never" mean "for a while." It asks how the past remains active in a life, and what responsibility asks of us now.[55]

Compassion that is not merely reassurance

How we speak to someone becomes part of what happens next. A warning does not enter an empty space; it enters a life already shaped by fear, conviction, suffering, and hope. Its truth matters, and so do the way it is offered and the response it makes possible. The question is now close to the original encounter: can severe speech open a way toward recognition without reducing the hearer to the judgment being challenged?

Freedom of thought need not leave us silent before a harmful view. The Third Mindfulness Training of the Order of Interbeing joins respect for another person's freedom with helping to transform fanaticism and narrowness through "loving speech and compassionate dialogue." Its commitment "not to force others" is not a commitment never to challenge them. The distinction concerns whether speech helps understanding become possible or demands submission to the speaker.[56]

An authentic warning draws attention to a real danger. It may need to be urgent, and its discomfort does not make it coercive. The Buddhist discourse to Prince Abhaya similarly

[53] John 5:24–29. The present possession of eternal life in 5:24 stands beside future resurrection and judgment in 5:28–29; neither dimension should be used to erase the other.

[54] Sister Annabel Laity (True Virtue), "The Three Dharma Seals," *The Mindfulness Bell* 74 (February 2017), section "The Three Times Inter-Are"; teaching given June 20, 2016, at Plum Village. The quoted sentence is Laity's, not an independently verified quotation from Thích Nhất Hạnh.

[55] The comparison concerns lived memory, expectation, and responsibility, not a single ancient theory of time. On the danger of a neat Hebrew/Greek opposition, see Henri Blocher, "Yesterday, Today, Forever," especially pp. 185–90. Neither lexical duration nor chronology is displaced by attending to how time is experienced.

[56] Order of Interbeing, *The Fourteen Mindfulness Trainings*, Third, "Freedom of Thought." Its prohibition of imposed belief belongs alongside its positive commitment to compassionate dialogue.

describes speech that is "factual, true, beneficial, but unendearing & disagreeable to others," with attention to the proper time for speaking it (*Majjhima Nikāya* 58, translated by Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu). That discourse, too, arises around a severe judgment. Compassion is not identified simply with what sounds reassuring.[57]

Heard in this light, Jesus's summons, questions, parables, and warning may belong to compassion in action. He challenges a judgment about his work that could also shape the understanding of those nearby. Compassion need not mean continuing an exchange on terms that allow harm to go unchallenged. Sometimes it calls for an interruption, a boundary, or a refusal to let another person's account of events become the only one that can be heard. The care involved includes people affected by the exchange, not only the person whose words are challenged.

That possibility rests on the danger being real and the response serving life, not on severity being valuable in itself. Whenever we speak from a position of spiritual, moral, or institutional authority, clear seeing, the needs of those addressed, and the effects of speech all matter; certainty about our loving intention cannot replace attention to them. Compassionate dialogue is not always safe or possible, and protecting oneself or others from harm need not be treated as a failure of openness. Nonviolence asks how harm may be resisted without being reproduced, and this may include protecting the space in which others can speak and be heard.

Remaining in the teaching

A koan-like engagement carries attention into the act of interpretation. The question includes the one asking it. What needs to change may be not only a proposed answer, but how we listen, speak, and respond to someone we had already decided we understood. The warning can touch our own attachment rather than remain a means of classifying other people.[58]

It can also ask us, imaginatively and carefully, to stand in more than one place in the scene: among the crowd who may be influenced, with the disciples learning how to recognize what is good, with the scribes whose judgment is being challenged, and with Jesus speaking under accusation. This does not pretend access to anyone's private mind. It prevents us from remaining safely outside the encounter while deciding what it means for

[57] *Majjhima Nikāya* 58, "Abhaya Sutta: To Prince Abhaya," translated by Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu (1997), Access to Insight edition revised November 30, 2013, third category in the sixfold account of speech. The opening concerns Devadatta and a severe prediction of hell and incurability. The comparison therefore distinguishes beneficial speech from agreeable speech; it does not dissolve judgment into reassurance.

[58] Thích Nhất Hạnh, "Bat Nha: a Koan." The letter's imagined first-person roles are literary devices within the teaching, not independent witness accounts. The proposed use of koan-like inquiry does not exempt a historical or ethical claim from examination.

everyone else. John gives this relation between teaching and lived understanding a direct expression:

> "If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples. Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."
>
> — John 8:31–32, NIV.[59]

The verb *menō* means to remain or abide. Knowing is joined to remaining in the word, not simply to possessing a settled explanation of it. In John's setting, the freedom concerns sin and the liberating work of the Son. The invitation has a practical depth: forgiveness, love, and repentance become known through the lives in which they are practiced. Study and inherited teaching belong to that process; so do the encounters that reveal where our understanding has not yet become action.

John also speaks of "whoever lives by the truth" coming into the light (3:21, NIV). The Greek phrase is ποιῶν τὴν ἀλήθειαν, *poiōn tēn alētheian*: literally, "doing the truth." Truth is not only something affirmed; it is enacted. An interpretation of mercy must become more than a persuasive account of mercy. Its meaning appears in whether we can tell the truth about harm, care for those affected, and remain willing to learn.[60]

6. The invitation before us

Returning to Mark 3, we can hear the sharp wake-up call. The promise of forgiveness and its breadth give the expression its startling force. Jesus speaks to people who have called the work of liberation evil, and the language of judgment confronts their own judgment. The warning brings the danger into the present encounter: while healing is treated as an enemy, it cannot be welcomed as healing. Its force, on this hearing, lies both in calling people to recognize what they are turning away from and in interrupting a judgment that others might begin to accept. Compassion may take the form of that interruption: care for those speaking, and care for those whose lives their words could affect.

The question of "eternal sin" remains, and its unresolved tension can continue to work on us. The Greek is emphatic, other Gospel passages sustain its severity, and interpreters have not reached a common answer. A compassionate purpose does not settle those differences. Yet uncertainty about the meaning of finality need not suspend the work of seeing, repentance, and responsibility. When understanding changes, the suffering already caused still calls for acknowledgment and whatever repair is possible; a new beginning is not an erased past.

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[59] John 8:31–36 (NIV); the audience in 8:31 is described as having believed, and the next verses concern slavery to sin and the Son's liberating work. The Greek says "you are really my disciples," not "you become my disciples."

[60] John 3:21; Greek *poiōn tēn alētheian*, "doing the truth." The full verse locates the deeds in God. The wording supports ethical enactment, not an account of private experience as the sole test of truth.

Humanizing Jesus does not require making him ordinary in the sense of insignificant. It means allowing his teaching to arise within a human life, grounded in time, place, culture, relationships, conflicts, grief, courage, and love. His Jewish inheritance belongs to that humanity, as do the people who shared it and understood it differently. The disciples, religious teachers, evangelists, and later interpreters belong to that arc of human experience. Reverence can bring us closer to these lives rather than place them beyond understanding.

An understanding of forgiveness can remain generous in its claims while becoming anemic in practice. We can defend mercy and fail to hear someone asking for accountability; we can defend truth while refusing an encounter that might deepen our understanding of it. The question is not whether we have found a formulation that no longer troubles us. It is whether we can remain with the teaching in a way that changes how we live. Whom have we already decided we understand, and what might become possible if we listened again?

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